

The Global Burden of Mental Illness: Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Global data overview (World, 2023) • Audience: public health policy analysts & program planners

Hundreds of Millions Affected

Lifetime risk of major depression is substantial

1 in 3

women experience major depression
(in their lifetime)

1 in 5

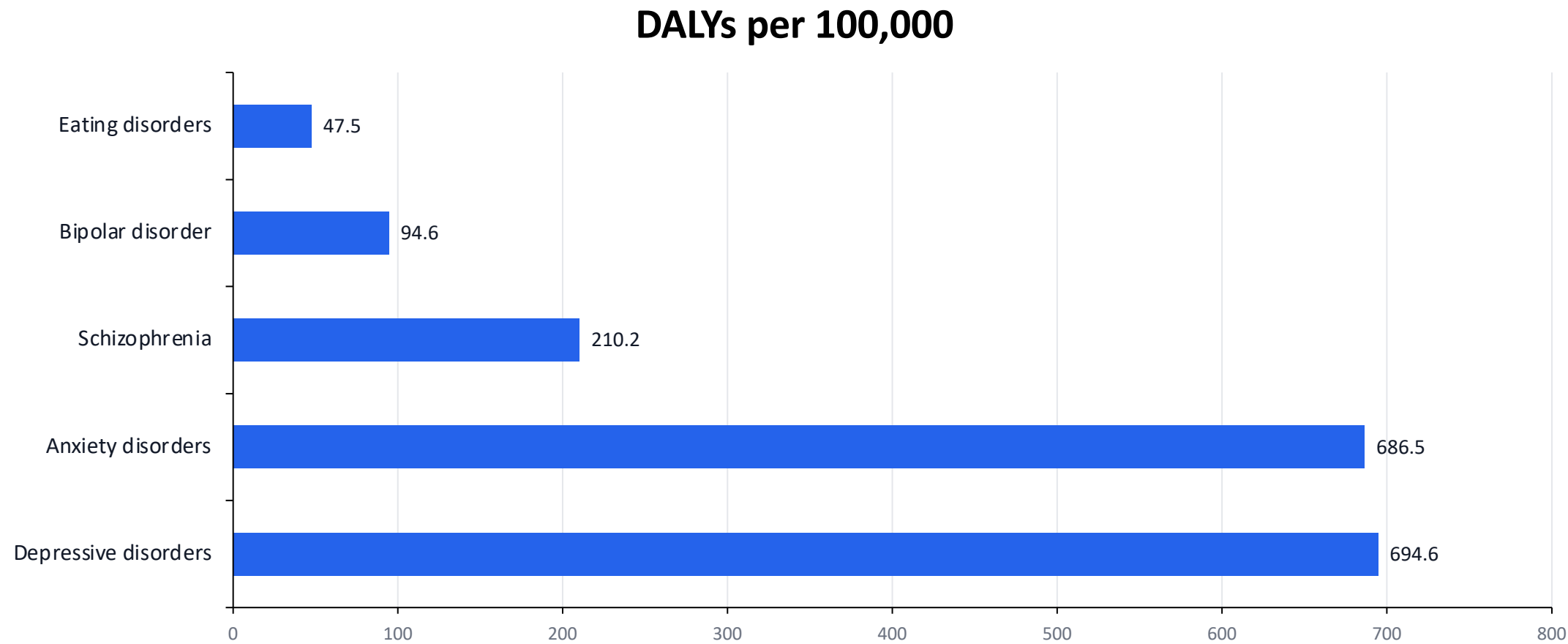
men experience major depression
(in their lifetime)

Mental health conditions span from common disorders (depression, anxiety) to less common but severe conditions (schizophrenia, bipolar disorder).

Poor mental health affects well-being, relationships, and ability to work—making it a core public health and policy concern.

Disease Burden by Category

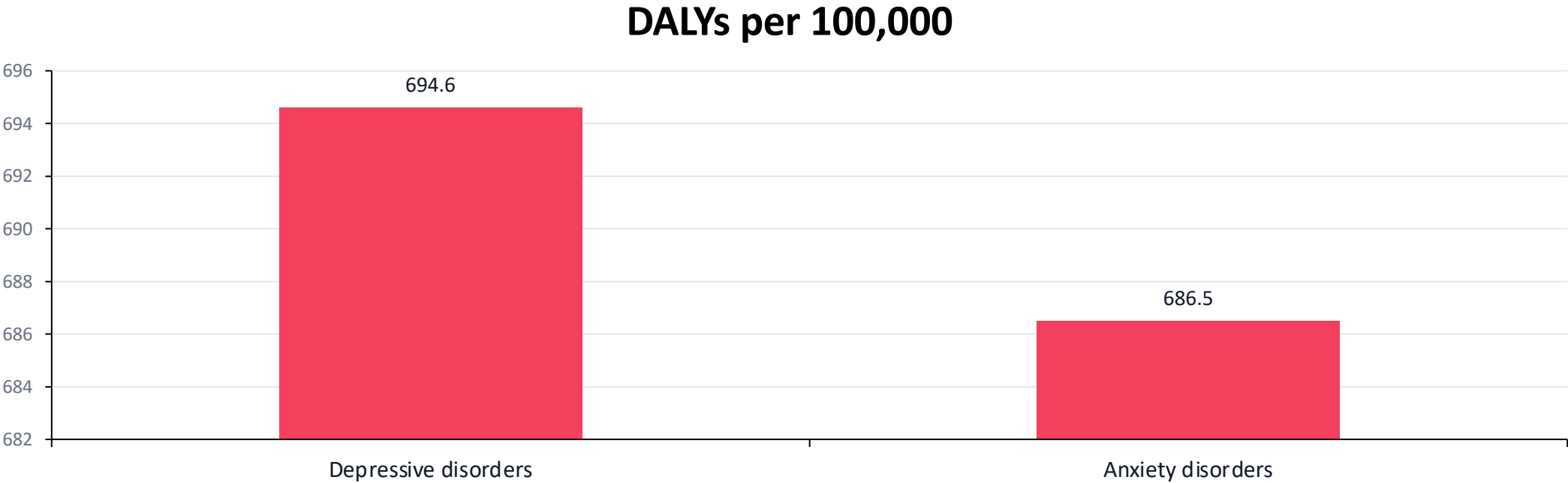
DALYs per 100,000 people (World, 2023)



Reference: figure_1 (Our World in Data / IHME).
Source: Our World in Data (2023), IHME GBD (2025). World, 2023.

Depression vs. Anxiety: Near Parity

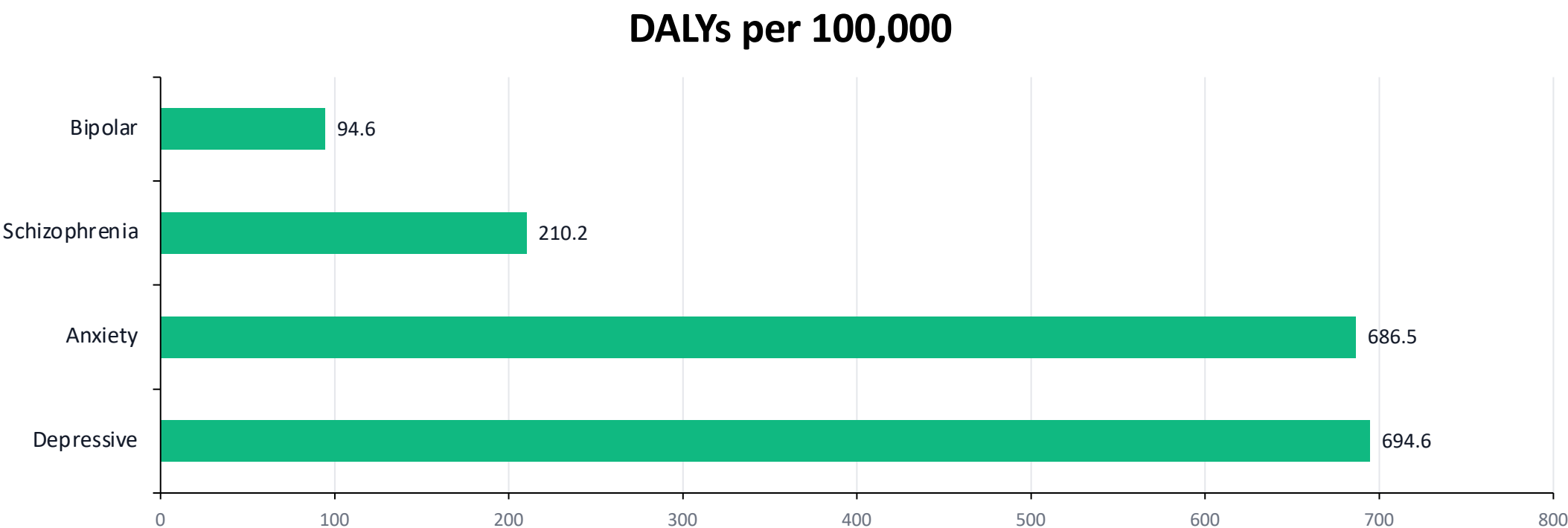
Nearly equal DALY burden worldwide



Depressive and anxiety disorders dominate the mental health burden, with nearly identical DALY rates (~695 vs ~687 per 100,000). Across these five categories, they account for roughly 80% of total DALYs—dwarfing other conditions.

Severe Conditions

Lower population burden; high disability for individuals



Schizophrenia contributes 210.2 DALYs per 100,000—reflecting severe disability despite lower prevalence.
Bipolar disorder contributes 94.6 DALYs per 100,000. Policy must sustain specialized services even while scaling care for common disorders.

Source: Our World in Data (2023), IHME GBD (2025). World, 2023.

The Treatment Gap

Treatments exist, but access and quality often fall short



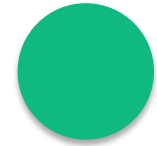
Stigma / disclosure barriers

Many people feel uncomfortable sharing symptoms.



Access constraints

Treatment is often lacking, especially in LMICs.



Quality gaps

Even where available, care may be poor quality.

Underreporting matters: discomfort with disclosure makes true prevalence hard to estimate—suggesting the real burden may be higher than reported.

How People Cope

Global surveys show wide variation across countries



Taking prescribed medication



Religious / spiritual activities



Talking to friends or family

The diversity of coping strategies highlights cultural, economic, and health-system differences—policy should be culturally sensitive rather than one-size-fits-all.

Reference: figure_2 (Our World in Data survey synthesis).

Key Takeaways for Policy

Prioritize high-burden conditions and close the treatment gap

Depression and anxiety represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs across major categories.

Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder have lower population-level burden but high individual disability—maintain specialized care.

Effective treatments exist, yet access and quality remain inadequate in many settings.

Stigma suppresses help-seeking and leads to underreporting—data and care improvements go together.

Scale evidence-based interventions for common disorders while sustaining services for severe conditions.